Archival narrative space and spatial narrative

Zeng, Jingyi
ruczengjingyi@gmail.com
Nankai University, China, People's Republic of

Xu, Yongjun
xyj@ruc.edu.cn
Renmin University of China, China, People's Republic of

Wang, Yujue
yujue.wang@whu.edu.cn
Wuhan University, China, People's Republic of

Niu, Li
rucniuli@ruc.edu.cn
Renmin University of China, China, People's Republic of

Wang, Lei
wlei@mail.sysu.edu.cn
Sun Yat-sen University, China, People's Republic of

Archival narrative emerged as an important research field in postmodernism, combining archival studies and narrative theory. Recently, the "spatial issue" in archival narrative research has become prominent, driven by the "spatial turn" in narrative theory, which has led to the development of narrative space and spatial narrative theories (Long 2015:26, Ryan et al. 2016:16). The basic understanding of narrative space is structured by the "story-discourse" dichotomy (Charman 1978:19). Additionally, changes in the management of archival objects have expanded archival practices from a "physical-social" binary space to a "physical-digital-social" trinary space (Zeng 2023:50). However, research on archival narratives in spatial dimensions remains underdeveloped, necessitating the exploration of digital archival spatial narratives.

This study uses inductive and deductive methods to analyze spatial representations in archival and narrative theory. It explores extending the binary space framework based on a trinary spatial integration. Focusing on story space and digital archives, it examines the "why," "what," and "how" of digital archival narratives (2W1H). It also analyzes discourse space, considering the shift from "inner (subject-facing)" to "outer (user-facing)" in the context of digital media, offering a comprehensive exploration of digital archival narrative channels. Taking the story of Chengdu as an example, explore the digital archival spatial narrative

practice combined with urban space.

This study develops a research framework for digital archival spatial narratives, centered around the "story—discourse" space, with digital archives as the subject and digital media as the tool. The narrative system for the story space consists of three components: First, by drawing on contemporary culture and the characteristics of modern society, it explores and elaborates on the cultural genes embedded within archives, linking them to specific archives, archival institutions, and their contents, thereby forming a semantic framework for digital archival narratives. Second, the narrative text, based on plot construction, forms a story outline (main narrative). Using knowledge graphs, this study stores multi-level, multi-granularity objects, such as "story—plot clusters—plot—plot units—narrative elements—archives." Third, considering the information consumption habits of digital-era users and accounting for cultural differences and thinking patterns, a "narrative toolkit" is created, comprising two modules: "storytelling" and "story presentation." The discourse system for the discourse space is structured in three parts: First, with the goal of enhancing the "explanatory power" of social reality and the "problem-solving power" of real-world issues, the study interprets and analyzes the multimodal discourse content of the archives, creating a cultural memory discourse framework that provides guidance for digital archival storytelling. Second, based on the "time-space—theme" narrative visualization logic, a framework for digital archival spatial narrative products is constructed. The study explores audience acceptance across different countries, cultures, thinking patterns, and digital environments, with the goal of improving discourse adaptability and developing customized solutions for segmented audiences. Finally, in response to the trend of differentiated communication, the study adopts segmented thinking to create a multi-dimensional media cluster, conducting re-

search on digital archival spatial narratives through a full-media matrix that integrates mobile, social, visual, and online-offline approaches, focusing on the characteristics of segmented products. Based on the urban storytelling of archival spatial narratives, the interaction between physical and abstract spaces is promoted. This interaction is facilitated by the spatial elements embedded in the archives, driving the coexistence of history and modernity within a broader temporal and spatial context. Chengdu's 4,500-year-old urban civilization and its 2,300-year history of city building come to life in the digital space, while cultural icons like the Three Kingdoms culture, Shu brocade, Shu embroidery, and the giant panda become known across the country and the world.

Focusing on the spatial turn in archival narratives, this study combines the interdisciplinary perspectives of "Archival Science" and "Narratology" to systematically consider the construction of archival narrative and discourse systems under the guidance of "spatial issues." Unlike the linear thinking of traditional narrative research, it integrates the spatial attributes of historical narratives and the tool attributes of digital narratives. However, this study has primarily focused on the combination of archival spatial narratives with urban spatial narratives, leaving the broader potential of "archive +" yet to be fully explored.

Bibliography

Chatman, Seymour . (1978): *Story and discourse: Narrative structure in fiction and film* . New York: Cornell University Press.

Long, Diyong . (2015): *A study of Spatial Narrative* . Beijing: SDX Joint Publishing Company.

Ryan, Marie-Laure / Kenneth, Foote / Maoz, Azaryahu . (2016): *Narrating space/spatializing narrative: Where narrative theory and geography meet.* Columbus: The Ohio State University Press.

Zeng, Jingyi . (2023): *Research on Archival Digital Editing and Studying Mode* . Beijing: China Commerce and Trade Press.